

The Friend Test

40 min · December Week 1

OBJECTIVE	Students deepen their Compassionate Witness practice through the Friend Test framework and apply it to a situation where they have been treating themselves with less fairness than they would treat a friend.
CASEL FOCUS	Self-Management: self-compassion as a regulation strategy · Social Awareness: applying empathy to the self
SCENARIO CARDS	Friend Test Scenario Pairs A & B — structured partner exchange
QUICK REVIEW	1–2 min: "In Lesson 4, we learned the four-step accountability structure and introduced the Friend Test. Quick: what is the Friend Test question?" (student answers) "Today we practice it — with each other. This is the lightest lesson of Unit 2. Use it to consolidate everything you've built."

ANCHOR CHART · THE FRIEND TEST — SIDE-BY-SIDE SPEECH BUBBLES

Draw this on the board **before class**. **LEFT BUBBLE:** "What I would say to my best friend in this situation."

RIGHT BUBBLE: "What I actually say to myself in this situation." Central question posted large: "**What is the gap between these two bubbles — and what does that gap tell you?**" Key message: "**The skill you already have is empathy toward friends. We are redirecting it toward yourself.**"

OPENING · 3 MINUTES

"Think about your closest friend. If they came to you in a genuinely hard moment — they had just failed something, made a mistake, been hurt — how would you talk to them? Now: is that how you talk to yourself in the same situation? Today we look at that gap."

DIRECT INSTRUCTION · STEPS 1 — 3

I The Friend Test Foundation 5 MIN

"The Friend Test is simple and powerful. When your internal critic is speaking, ask: would I say this to my closest friend in the same situation? If the answer is no — the critic is not being fair. The Compassionate Witness says what you would say to the friend."

Point to both speech bubbles. "**The skill you already have is empathy toward friends. We are redirecting it toward yourself.**"